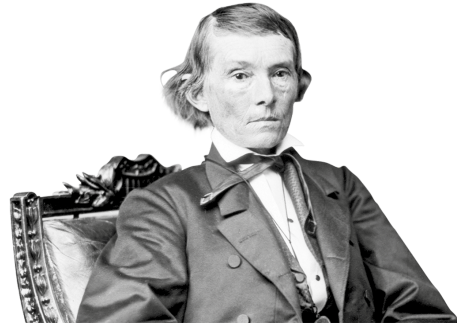


ALEXANDER HAMILTON STEPHENS

Alexander Stephens was a long-serving Georgia Representative in the U.S. Congress with Unionist instincts and a Whig background, who found himself elected as Confederate vice president. He had supported the Compromise of 1850, and he argued that Lincoln's election was not an immediate threat to slavery. Nevertheless, he seemed fatalistic in private about the inevitability of secession, and he helped write the Confederate constitution.



On March 21, 1861, Stephens, who was an enslaver of more than 30 people, gave his "cornerstone" speech, declaring slavery the bedrock of the Confederacy. A believer in states' rights, he quarreled with Jefferson Davis over his use of emergency powers and opposed conscription. He returned to politics after the war, even aligned himself with Republicans for a time, and was elected governor of Georgia in 1882.

The upper South's dilemma

The new Confederacy began its preparations for war, but the fate of the states of the upper South remained ambiguous. Virginia, Arkansas, and Missouri elected conventions with Unionists in the majority, while North Carolina and Tennessee chose not to have conventions at all. The border states of Maryland, Kentucky, and Delaware, where slavery existed in a limited form, also hung in the balance. While these states refused to join the Confederacy, they also made it clear that they would oppose any Federal attempt to coerce the states of the lower South back into the Union.

In this confused situation, the sitting President James Buchanan did next to nothing to address the problems. With the chief executive acting as a lame duck, President-elect Lincoln sought to support Unionist sentiment in the South, while remaining committed to the Free-Soil principles of the Republican Party's platform.

When Lincoln assumed the powers and office of the presidency on March 4, 1861, he faced the thorny political dilemma of how to respond to the newly formed Confederacy's seizure of Federal